

The Indigenous Ranger Biosecurity Program (IRBP) helps protect Australia's more than \$81 billion agricultural industries by partnering with Indigenous rangers in northern Australia to undertake biosecurity surveillance for exotic pests, diseases and weeds. A key element of the IRBP is capability building initiatives like the Northern Australia Indigenous Ranger Biosecurity Forum.

The forum brings up to 200 Indigenous rangers from remote communities across northern Australia together with trainers and support staff from agencies that share an interest in biosecurity. It is the only community forum of its type in northern Australia and provides valuable face-to-face delivery of targeted biosecurity training, awareness and educational activities, knowledge-sharing and networking opportunities for Indigenous rangers.

Each forum is delivered in partnership with an Indigenous stakeholder via a grant opportunity.

In addition to biosecurity, the agenda covers topics such as conservation and land management, remote field skills, traditional knowledge and leadership.

The Ranger Forum:

- provides a key opportunity to increase biosecurity skills and knowledge in the Indigenous ranger network
- facilitates Indigenous-led workshops, presentations and sessions, helping rangers learn from each other for stronger learning outcomes
- engages Indigenous rangers in unique practical activities
- fosters two-way learning between Indigenous rangers, DAFF scientists and other stakeholders, blending traditional ecological knowledge with western science
- connects a diverse network of Indigenous rangers who are passionate about working on country in northern Australia
- establishes lasting partnerships and friendships and fosters pride and collegiality amongst rangers
- supports aspirations of Indigenous ranger groups and motivates and empowers rangers
- provides an opportunity to be on-Country in northern Australia, welcomed by traditional owners and following cultural protocols

2025 Ranger Forum

The 2025 Northern Australia Indigenous Ranger Biosecurity Forum was hosted by the Carpentaria Land Council Aboriginal Corporation (CLCAC). Attendees were welcomed to Mougibi Country in Burketown, Queensland, by Traditional Owners, the Gangalidda Garawa People.

The forum featured tailor-made biosecurity workshops, hands-on activities, and yarning circles.

One of the highlights of the forum were the insights shared by BirdLife Australia on the ancient flyways of migratory shorebirds, gathered from more than 20 years of studies.

2025 Northern Australia Indigenous Ranger Biosecurity Forum - Moungebii | Burketown

Hosted by CLCAC - Carpentaria Land Council Aboriginal Corporation

In partnership with - Australian Government, Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry; Top Watch Biosecurity

Welcome to Moungebii, Burketown, spoken in Gangalidda language by Mangubadijarri Yanner, Chairperson, Gangalidda and Garawa Native title Corporation.

"Dai Mairayara Mangubadijara. Nyara Gangarira Lurugu Gunamola Nejda Marangarraulummiri wanjala Nejda Bordavajai mambaliya. Gawa Nida Dolga Dulmaramungibi."

Tommy Wilson

Ranger Coordinator - CLCAC Chairperson

Wellesley Islands Rangers

"Last time we had one of these big events was back in 2018, having northern Indigenous rangers from east coast to the west coast and the Torres Strait down to the Gulf.

This event is helping other Indigenous ranger groups cope with their biosecurity activity they do on country. So we've got a lot of workshops happening in the next few days."

Renae Todd

Director - Indigenous Ranger Biosecurity Program

"So the north is quite unique in that we're very close to our near northern neighbours. It's also that we have, you know, winds that can bring exotic pests and diseases in. But it's 10,000 kilometres of coastline that we're trying to cover. So what we want to be able to do is continue to build biosecurity knowledge, partnering with Indigenous rangers who know country very well, and generations of looking after and caring for land and sea."

Jameson Wilson

Ranger - Wellesley Islands Rangers

"It's good to have these sort of events and forums like this because, my people don't know what biosecurity really does and I feel that we can share our knowledge, we can share it, like with the biosecurity given us, we can go out and be, make our families aware of what's on country and what might not be native to our land."

John Fejo

Senior Ranger Coordinator - Goondoi

"You know, we have a responsibility as First Nations people to look after our brothers and sisters, not just doing the ranger work, but also understanding the governance side and building that capacity for future generations."

Olivia Nulgit

Ranger - Dambimangari Aboriginal Corporation

"It's really good, it's interesting the things that they come up with and the new ideas and then take back some ideas of what other rangers bring up in like the yarning circles, monitoring and like all sorts of different stuff that us rangers do."

Peter Finnin

First Assistant Secretary - Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry

"One of the key elements of the Indigenous Ranger biosecurity programme is the opportunity that we have to partner with Traditional Owners on country to help us in the important work of trying to understand if and when pests and diseases that could impact all of Australia are entering into the country."

Milmarja Yanner

Ranger - Gangalidda and Garawa Rangers

"I think one of these forums just happening maybe every couple of years and stuff will bring a broader understanding for them and how to improve their ranger groups, and in turn improve Australia as well with the Biosecurity, border and risk and preventing such foreign diseases from coming into the country."

John Hodgson

Land and Environment Manager - CLCAC

"Events like this are very important for ranger groups. As you would've seen today, there's been a number of workshops, there'll be workshops across the whole forum to teach Indigenous rangers from across northern Australia some new skills. Through these events with sharing knowledge and stories that will help strengthen biosecurity efforts across northern Australia."

Desmond Armstrong

Ranger Coordinator - Gangalidda and Garawa Rangers

"It's just good to network and see how the other rangers do stuff, you know. Like because we we've worked hard to get to where we are, so we're just going to learn from other rangers so we can collaborate and the more positive we get out of it the better, you know, so we'll learn other things we can do, maybe do something better here that they do, you know. So stuff like that, so it's just all about doing better in the country and taking care of it."

2023 Ranger Forum

The 2023 Northern Australia Indigenous Biosecurity Ranger Forum was organised and hosted by the Mandubarra Aboriginal Land and Sea Incorporated at Kurrimine Beach, Queensland, from 17 to 19 October. The forum brought together 268 Indigenous Rangers, coordinators and biosecurity staff for 3 days of hands-on and immersive workshops, yarning circles and cultural experiences.

Mel

It's been a journey. It was only a few short months ago that we got the news that we were successful to host the Northern Australia Indigenous Biosecurity Forum. In that time, Mandubarra and support staff and family, TO's, we've all gotten together and it's been an incredible experience to see what we've set up, what we've accomplished. I'm so proud of everything that they have achieved.

Derek

I from Tiwi Islands, 80k's north of Darwin. Opening ceremony, like Welcome to Country. I mean that really stand out for me. That there is like proper welcoming to country, you know like proper respectful for everyone. And not only that, even back where we come from, you know, if you don't do that, something bad might happen. It was good too, that they did that for us.

Laura

I come from Warraber, up in Torres Strait.

John

Moa Island. At Moa, we've got, we are more or less the largest island out in the Torres Strait, coming down this way and meeting other groups or working with DAFF. Seeing how important that we sort of work closely with DAFF in stopping disease and pests coming from the Straits, down to the south.

Laura

Over the last three days, I've learned a lot, how we can improve up in Torres Strait with the Ranger program.

Yeah, the highlight is the drone that could do the AI with the ghost nets monitoring. So that was really eye opening for myself that, yes, we live in a small community but there is an easier way to get to the bottom of ghost nets.

Deborah

NIAA has been really pleased to partner with Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry on this. We've been working together on the Biosecurity Rangers program for a number of years and it's just a great example of a First Nations-led approach to managing country, managing sea country and keeping a strong and healthy culture and connection to the land. It's been really great to see such a diverse group of people learning from each other and combining practical skills and experience with hearing from a number of experts working on different issues.

It resonates really well with our commitment to closing the gap and meeting the socioeconomic outcomes of that and working differently in partnership with Indigenous Australians. It's a great example of seeing that all happening in practice.

Wayne

It's a really great way and a great opportunity for us to all see and hear about the great work that Ranger groups do.

And in saying that's also for them to show the lessons learned, some of the things that they're working on right now and sharing that with other Ranger groups from across northern Australia. But also to share with agencies like ours and others who've come on board to support the Indigenous Ranger Biosecurity Program in particular, and how that's also making a difference and to see what kind of a difference that's making for community as well.

The other part is really about strengthening the partnerships, the connections, the collaboration. So that's between Ranger groups, but also Ranger groups and agencies like ours, DAFF. So it's really about that and giving everybody that opportunity to come together face to face, which is something that you can't overstate the value of to, to hear from people on the ground as to what you know, what they like about what we're doing, but also things that we can work on with them to do a bit better.

So that's really the big learning curve for me. And the thing I take the most out of this, especially in terms of the engagement and hearing the stories of what people are doing on ground and seeing some of the things that they're able to show, but also teach me about the work that they do.

Matthew

I'm from far north Queensland, Cairns up in Yirrganydji Country.

Unknown

Somebody's doing plant ID just over here, just learning all of that with the Rangers and then getting involved because we have similar plants that is growing out on our country, sharing ideas how they protect it and how they get rid of it.

Roh

As part of our closing ceremony we are holding a gala dinner and everything on the tables tonight has been collected off our Mandubarra Country, from the shells and the coral, to the sand and the greenery has all come off Mandubarra Country.

I was lucky enough to have met with our Mandubarra Elders to be granted permission to travel to the islands and to our very sacred and special sites to collect these items. Also on the tables are little hand-painted bags that were painted by our Junior Rangers at a workshop that we held on the September school holidays. And inside the little bags, we have little plastic turtle keychains that were made by a company called Zero Plastics Australia.

We've chosen this company because their values really align with ours with keeping our waterways free from debris and rubbish. And we've chosen the turtle because the Bajigal in our language is a Mandubarra totem and we just wanted all of our Rangers to be able to take a little piece of Mandubarra home with them today.

Joseph

I think the opportunity to be a host as a clan group man of this country, it's very honorable and a privilege to showcase our beautiful country. Not a lot of people have the privilege of having the two World Heritage sites that meet.

So the Great Barrier Reef meets the tropical rainforest, which is pretty special. We like to think we live in paradise, to showcase paradise to the rest of the, you know, Australia and the mob that have come over from everywhere and also to have the New Zealand delegates come across from so far to be able to make that possible and to have them here is just, yeah, that's amazing.

And who knows this with this opportunity, it brings more opportunity for us to travel to other countries and other parts of Australia and things and so on and so on.

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